



SIGNALLING AND SHRM: THE MICROECONOMICS OF INCLUSION (2026)

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THESIS TITLE:

Do SHRM Signalling Practices, Compared to Conventional HRM Approaches, Affect How Candidates Perceive the Employee Journey? *Investigating the “Microeconomics of Inclusion” with Survey Evidence*

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Abstract

By hypothesising that signalling practices as organizational cues are designed to communicate SHRM initiatives to external applicants and internal employees, this paper assesses responses using a two-staged least squared (2SLS) regression model and instrumental variable approach. Making use of a 10-point Likert scale as a survey method, this paper presents a study into whether any correlation exists between the perceived attitudinal judgements of candidates about the employee journey, and data taken from a depression scale collected from Understanding Society and other sources.

Keywords: Inclusion, SHRM, Instrumental Variable, 2SLS

1 | Introduction

Signalling theory (Spence, 1973) is widely considered to be a seminal work which extends a microscopic lens into the origins of worker behavioural incentives. However, Spence's central argument, that signals act as communicative devices between firm and worker, such as when workers invest more in education signalling to employers that a higher wage is expected has not been reconciled with recent work on signalling (Kolotilin, 2024) and SHRM. This paper presents a study into how workers perceive HRM strategies both internally and externally in a VUCA environment (Barney, 1991) and how this links to signalling throughout the employee journey (Celani and Singh, 2011; Mayaki, 2024; Miller and Doyle, 2025). The study investigates several reoccurring themes in the work of Miller and Doyle (2025) and the premise of a recently published research article on signalling theory. It extends Miller and Doyle's work by collecting anonymous responses to a 10-point Likert scale consisting of 11 questions and undertakes a 2SLS regression analysis (Chen, 2019), with an instrumental variable (IV).

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2 | Data Sources

Data for this project will be from Understanding Society (UKHLS), the Life Opportunities Survey (Waves 1-3); and the OECD Employment & Labour Market Statistics (each dataset from 2010-2015). Selected variables used in the study include '*jbatt*' which is a variable proxy representing the survey response concerning one's main attraction to one's current job, '*jwbs2_dv*' which is a job-related depression scale, and finally a variable proxy for 'social contract' which is derived from the Life Opportunities Survey. Table 2.1 illustrates these variables as one-half of the simultaneous equation system, where the problem is always to balance the incentives of the worker with the motivation of the employer in a long-run equilibrium.

Table 2.1: Modelling structural data using variables for worker incentive

Optimality conditions	Representation
Main attraction of current job	J_i
Job depression scale (dependent variable)	D_i
Social contract (health condition)	S_i
Length of sickness absence	L_i

In Table 2.2 the study assumes that the employer observes (or has full knowledge of) the productivity of current workers, profitability of their business unit, and thereafter sets its offered wage arbitrarily *above* the market wage to attract new workers, as this is a proven method of ensuring the avoidance of workers who are likely to shirk or to a lesser extent, those who signal low productivity levels.

Table 2.2: Modelling structural data using variables for employer motivation

Optimality conditions	Representation
New worker productivity signal	U_i
Profitability of firm F	H_i^*
Wage level of firm F	W_i

3 | Methodology

The study builds on the recently published work of Miller and Doyle (2025). The nature of the newly formatted survey questions (See Appendices) remains consistent with Miller and Doyle original survey after a transformation from open format to closed. The interrogation format was ultimately changed from open to closed to better quantify responses of employees. The ten new questions ascend from 1-10 in a Likert scale where 1 equates to a strong disagreement and 10 equates to the highest possible level of agreement. The strength of this format is it allows structural estimates to be derived when these survey variables are embedded into an objective function (a constrained maximisation problem). As in Table 2.1 and 2.2, the two-stage least squared (2SLS) regression model (Chen, 2019) is defined as the dependent variable: Y representing a depression scale, an intercept β_0 , an observed Likert Scale variable (job attractiveness) and its estimator β_1 and X_1 , and finally a residual or error term, ε :

$$(3.1) \quad Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X_1 + \beta_2 X_2 + \varepsilon$$

In the 2SLS, the first stage (the instrument) identifies a dummy variable (Z) that is correlated with the HRM signal (the 'treatment') but is uncorrelated with the depression scale's error term. For example, $Z = 1$ when an employer provides a list of frequently requested adjustments and $Z = 0$ when this list is not provided in the recruitment process. In the 2SLS second stage (the outcome), the study uses the predicted values from the first stage to estimate the impact on the dependent variable Y . In terms of variables, it was assumed that one key variable emerged as a primary source in the regression function, that is: the measure of job 'attractiveness'. The depression scale Y is derived from a secondary source of data. These inferences, in part, form questions which in turn are separate to the primary research questions and are secondary in nature. Given that recent research demonstrates how inclusive teams can be 30% more productive than those which do not include diverse employees, and with Gen Z entering the workforce – over 50% of whom have some sort of neurodivergent condition, the broad research topic identifies a contemporary problem with its roots in a recent report (Youth Future's Foundation, 2025).

4 | Hypothesis

As an interdisciplinary topic, this thesis is partly covered by *signalling* (psychology), *applicant attraction* (HRM), *employee wellbeing* (HRM) and *labour market analysis* (game theory). The following hypotheses are subject to supervisory changes and will be honed and amended as and when new information in the literature is discovered, reviewed and internalised. In order, these initial hypotheses read as follows:

Hypothesis 1: The average worker views the firms signal intent to accommodate as inclusive.

Hypothesis 2: Firms choose to allocate resources between signalling and DEI initiatives.

Hypothesis 3: Firms signalling higher average wages tend to be less inclusive.

Hypothesis 4: Firms harnessing the power of AI can achieve high wages *and* be optimally inclusive.

The importance of the research survey should not be understated. Specifically, the topic is important because it seeks to enquire into how diverse job applicants perceive their roles in the organization *prior to* being onboarded as employees (in other words, it asks how *neurodiverse* applicants interact as job candidates) through the proxy of website recruiting activities. The seminal applied instance of this research topic is the online ratings and HRM signalling paper pioneered by Chang and Chin (2018) who test evidence to investigate the hypothesis that three things are likely to occur prior to onboarding:

1. A high-commitment HRM strategy is pursued and that firms conduct recruitment online via a website.
2. The firm may initiate a signal to the receiver via a website. Such a signal concerns the nature of its high-commitment HRM strategy.
3. This signal initiates an effect on the employees' online ratings.

The authors (Chang and Chin, 2018) argue for five important hypotheses which form the starting point for this study:

- 1) Firms with more high-commitment HRM will signal more HRM information on websites.
- 2) Firms signalling more HRM information on websites will experience a trend of more applications.
- 3) Firms' signalling of HRM information on websites fully mediates the effect of the firms' commitment HRM on recruitment.
- 4) Firms' *actual* HRM influences employees after experience outcomes such that firms' commitment HRM will increase online ratings.
- 5) Firms' signalling of HRM will not increase an employees' online ratings if the effect of commitment HRM (on recruitment) is controlled.

My research will aim to extend a gap on this topic by focusing on firm expenditure, capabilities, and resources, asking a question not currently addressed by the literature on signalling – how these factors affect competitive advantage given the specific context of attribution theory (Guest, 2021).

5 | Literature Review

Strategic narratives (Miles and Snow, 1984; Lengnick-Hall and Lengnick-Hall, 1988) of HRM tend to focus historically on unitarian forms of stakeholder capitalism, where the shareholder is prioritised (Wright and Steinbach, 2022) but as chapter 8 of Van Riel and Fombrun (2007) indicates, shareholders are not the only stakeholders in an organization. One might counteract the pros of signalling by arguing that equilibrium analysis of corporate communication in HRM is too hypercritical, interested in detail which does not exist and is along the lines of the basic-hard approach, which fails to acknowledge the 'H' in HRM (Van Riel and Fombrun, 2007),

The gap in the signalling literature is not very vast but extends to recent work by Kolotilin *et. al.* (2024) and his formal proofs with application to media censorship and later to workers and firms. There is little or no example in Kolotilin *et. al.* (2024) of any structural estimation via survey evidence achieved through primary research. The work of van Damme and Guth (1989) and thereafter van Damme and Guth (1991) refers explicitly to Spence (1973) in a model focused on perfect equilibria and, as previously demonstrated in Mayaki (2024) via 'disagreement points', and in what van Damme and Guth refer to as 'uniformly perfect equilibria', worker and firm frictions are a significant element to equilibrium search and matching models.

Here, in the view of Spence (1973) the notion of hiring is made analogous to the rationale of purchasing a ticket for a lottery draw, which itself is a problematic notion due to the euphemisms of risk, value and eventual loss being invoked. This rationale of adopting such a gamble is best described per a model composed by Brown and Sessions (2004). Spence argues that there is often an element of informational asymmetry pertaining to full knowledge of the average worker's capability in the job prior to such a lottery concept being invoked. Assuming the lottery concept is associated with information that is rarely fully disseminated, an employer's perception of this lottery gamble is what Spence (1973) defines as a "primary interest" due to the uncertainty involved in making the proposed hire when weighed against the wages offered by the employer to the worker as compensation for services rendered. When discussing the lottery, we speak here of a singular instance of a repeated game. The terms of reference adhered to by Spence, constitute very strict and formal belief system for his term sheet mapping the employer's perception of the lottery process. There are two kinds of observable attributes mentioned in Spence's article: Indices and signals (Spence, 1973; p. 357). The term "indices" refers to "immutable" attributes observed by the employer amongst participants in the hiring 'lottery', attributes such as race or sex. This is followed closely by the term "signals", which references alterable attributes or those which can be manipulated by the candidate, such as education and experience. For the purposes of Spence's research, age is considered as an alterable attribute and is therefore seen to be an index. Signals and indices are seen to be "parameters" in the conditional probability distribution reflecting the "beliefs" of an employer.

Navigating this landscape of DEI in recruitment can be oftentimes a complex pursuit. Upon reflection with some experience and exposure to high-level dialogue gained through the Business in the Community (BITC) Opening Doors program, it's fair and proper to infer proportionality. By this, I mean the idea that work is a lottery is not an appropriate lens to view employment dynamics. Much of the work found in the recommendations of the 2024 Autistica report authored in collaboration with Sir Robert Buckland KC can be supported by academic literature. If the Autistica report identifies the scenarios and problem faced by Autistic job applicants, then Miller and Doyle (2025) most certainly shed further light on this problematisation of a many-to-one 'lottery' scenario by providing what one might call a dialectical synthesis to the concerns highlighted in the report. According to Miller and Doyle (2025) the article mentions the theoretical framework of Khan et. al. (2023) whose literature review and empirical study on the topic is the only post-COVID era work used as authority, but the article also acknowledges that research in the area of inclusive signalling to neurodiverse applicants is relatively limited. When extending Khan et. al. (2023)'s ideas for further research in a HR context, Miller and Doyle (2025) apply a systems-based analysis of "signalling" theory (or rather a systematic approach based on academic literature) in the hiring and selection process to uncover a consummate view that the inclusion of the neurodiverse job applicant in the workplace is paramount. Both co-authors argue organisations should go *beyond* the business case for diversity in recruitment by making the process itself clearer.

One can divide the approach for achieving such an eventuality as follows. Firstly, Miller and Doyle treatise an argument in favour of neuroinclusive approaches by encouraging proactivity from the employer. The line of thinking goes: If an employer provides a list of 'frequently requested adjustments' then this action is therefore a proactive signal to candidates who may require such adjustments to participate in the process. Likewise, by sufficiently educating recruitment staff and hiring managers involved in the act of recruitment and selection on what "neurodivergent *behaviours*" are, and by thereafter implementing a follow-up action: prioritising diversity, equity and inclusion over the Spencian view of hiring as a lottery, we arrive at a mechanism which appreciates neurodiversity as a recruitment priority. Critiques may argue this may create a consequentialist dependence on prior training investment.

In contrast to Miller and Doyle's pragmatism on the subject of signalling approaches, Celani and Singh (2011) have conducted an analysis of signalling theory from a multi-level perspective (with the use of 'contextual effects'). By multi-level, or multi-hierarchical (affecting various modes of the organisation; navigating the macro-level, the meso-level, through to the individual-level) the assessment of how recruitment-related signals is seen to reveal unknown characteristics of the organization becomes more stratified. The theory posited provides links between individual and organisation-level signals from recruitment activities. Links are made between market signals and instrumental or symbolic applicant inferences. Celani and Singh (2011) are concerned with outcomes (as opposed to the interest of Davies *et. al.* (2023) for example who are concerned with recruitment *methods* faced by Autistic adults. They therefore take up a consequentialist position (a

position which derives itself from the moral philosophy of consequentialism). By introducing their topic in such a way, Celani and Singh conclude by challenging readers via invitation to study a gap in the signalling literature ~ signalling from a recruiter perspective i.e. from the organisation's perspective. This means to imply that the organisation (recruiter or hiring manager) does indeed perceive and internalise what Spence (1973) defines as 'alterable' attributes (for instance, the highest level of education signalled by the candidate or the candidate's length of experience/number of promotions or career highlights). Signalling theory when viewed through the Spencian lens is therefore arguably either angst and menace on the one hand or catalyst and predicator on the other. By contrasting the approaches of Celani and Singh (2011) with that of Miller and Doyle (2025) it is possible to observe how in hindsight both authors take completely opposing perspectives on signalling in the context of neurodiversity. Chang and Chin (2018) on the other hand define signalling less altruistically but as the communication of unique information or rather "the sending out of information that competitors cannot easily imitate" analysing HRM signalling on each firm's website over a three-year period. Signalling therefore becomes important in job markets where numerous employers compete to "increase market share". Chang and Chin (2018) stress the importance of firm actions and separating equilibrium.

The work of David Guest has been prominent in HRM literature for well over 30+ years. In Guest (2021), the author studies the staff members of bank branches and primarily defines signalling theory as "communication *by* and *within* an organisation", in contrast to evidence from Laker *et. al.* (2025). Citing Bowen and Ostroff (2004) as part of an integrated framework to study attribution theory, Guest (2021) concludes that signalling theory is to be viewed as a "*distinctive*" approach to the HRM process. He acknowledges limitations of cross-sectional methodology and calls for longitudinal research approaches. The article by Bowen and Ostroff (2004) is one which touches upon multi-level relationships between HRM and organisational performance through psychological "climate" as an example of higher-order social structures (other examples include organisational culture and organisational role structure, and organisational sensemaking (which is a design thinking principle). (p.205). Bowen and Ostroff (2004) highlight the additional importance of "social context theory" where formal roles are defined by organisational systems and "maintenance subsystems".

6 | Results

[To be completed]

7 | Discussion

Axiology which is the study of the science of value (Bahm, 2021) is indeed an important aspect to consider when developing a theoretical understanding of recruitment. Contextualising and internalising the scientific value of the process requires an understanding of the employer's brand value, and its positioning relative proximity to the preferences of ideal applicants and other organizations.

AI as an umbrella term for concepts machine learning, NLP, computer vision and other key algorithmic concepts. Some gaps certainly do exist in the form of "*minimal information*" available concerning the effects of bipolar depression in later life, one of the more pronounced gaps in the literature is the more recent focus on Artificial Intelligence ("AI") and employment balances for neurodivergent neurotypical applicants (Mirowska and Arsenyan, 2025; Smith *et. al.*, 2025) which assumes the capture of those who suffer from Bipolar I or II. AI has been argued to carry the potential to promote or affect various types of diversity, to avoid the consequence of overexposure to unconscious biases, and to help design more comprehensive signalling approaches to attract talent, recruit and retain new employees and to develop an overarching organisational focus on *cultural* diversity (Ramroop, 2025) more generally. According to an open access paper by Chilunjika, *et. al.* (2022), gaps exist in the research on AI's application to HRM in the public sector.

ENDS

8 | Conclusion

[To be completed]

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10 | Appendices

1. What attracts you to an organization? *Changes to* - I am attracted by the offer of interview accommodation when applying.
2. How do you perceive if a potential employer is inclusive during recruitment? *Changes to* - I am increasingly aware of inclusive wording and the behaviours of recruiters.
3. How does this impact you? *Changes to* - These impact me in a positive way.
4. What was your experience of applying to your current organization? *Changes to* - My experience of applying to my current organization was enjoyable.
5. Do you have other experiences that have been the same, or different? *Changes to* - I have had other enjoyable experiences that have been similar.
6. Do you disclose your neurodivergence during recruitment? *Changes to* - I am happy to disclose my neurodivergence during recruitment processes.
7. What has been your experience of disclosing or not disclosing? *Changes to* - My experience of disclosure has been amicable.
8. What has been your experience of adjustments during recruitment? *Changes to* - My experience of adjustments made during recruitment have been reasonable.
9. When you have been at your best during recruitment, that's like what? *Changes to* - To perform my best during a job interview, I require a specific adjustment. (Please state the specific adjustment you require during interview in your last response)
10. How did the organization help you do your best? *Changes to* - My organization helps me to perform my best.